for the poor has ensured that the growth is inclusive and sustainable. His schemes like Swachh Bharat, Jan Dhan Yojana, Direct Benefit Transfer and Ayushman Bharat have brought transformative changes in India.

Q. You have faced a lot of criticism in other areas of your business, whether in Australia, Sri Lanka or the investments made in various parts in India...
Gautam Adani is a product of a democratic India. Protests, criticism and allegations are essential parts of a vibrant democracy. In fact, they define democracy. I am a firm believer that our democracy has given us economic freedom and opportunities and we all have benefited from it. Now we can't complain and cherry-pick about other aspects of democracy which have their own functional values within the boundary of the law. We are in the infrastructure sector which is the most difficult space to work in. I have a very open mind towards criticism. For me, the message has always been more important than the messenger. I always introspect and try to understand the other's point of view. I am conscious that I am neither perfect nor am I always right. Every criticism gives me an opportunity to improve myself.

Q. Despite all the criticism, you have never given up. Is that part of the Adani culture?
Yes, giving up has never been part of Adani's culture. Over the years, the group has developed a strong and professional team with endless energy and a problem-solving approach. We are always looking at solutions. Having honed my skills in such a dynamic democracy like India, me and my group are confident that we can deliver and do business in any part of the world. I have faced adversity and crisis from childhood. Each occasion taught me several valuable lessons and made me stronger. It is why I always tell my team: 'Never waste a crisis'.



"Girls like Arunima and Kiran—both of them amputees—are the real heroes of *naya* India. Could there be anything more motivating than such courage, determination and valour in the face of adversity?"

Q. You are also betting big on green energy, especially solar and hydrogen. How confident are you that they will become viable businesses in the near future given the costs of converting, say green hydrogen into fuel, including storing it?
Green energy is very close to my heart and energy transition is not only a huge business opportunity but also our responsibility to future generations. The government of India has brought a very attractive production linked incentive (PLI) scheme which has made the green hydrogen business viable and attractive. In fact, I am very confident that with this enabling support we will not only meet domestic demand but soon become a green hydrogen exporter.

Q. First-generation entrepreneurs like Dhirubhai Ambani faced many difficulties. You are also a first-generation entrepreneur. Who do you look up to as a mentor?
Dhirubhai Ambani is a source of inspiration for millions of entrepreneurs in India. He showed us how a humble man without any backing or resources and against all odds can not only set up a world-class business group but also leave behind a legacy. Being a first-generation entrepreneur with humble beginnings, I am deeply inspired by him.

Q. Looking forward, how do you see India's economy grow in the year ahead?
In our 75 years of independence, it took us 58 years to get to our first trillion dollars of GDP, 12 years to get to the next trillion and just five years for the third trillion. But now, if you look at our pace of social and economic reforms, I see India adding a trillion dollars to its GDP every 12 to 18 months within the next decade. I am very optimistic about India's growth and prosperity. This optimism comes from the fact that in 2050, we will have a young India of 1.6 billion people with a median age of 38. We will also have the world's largest middle-class population. This demographic dividend combined with the largest middle class will spur growth and prosperity in India, making it a $30 trillion economy. So, clearly, this century belongs to India.

Q. Finally, many experts think a global recession is likely in 2023. Are you concerned by such predictions?
I am a born optimist and never lose hope. I recall that many pundits had painted a similar gloom scenario for India during the 2008 global financial crisis. But India was successful in beating the prediction. I am optimistic that the next Union budget will provide a great opportunity to address all these concerns. A strong focus on capital expenditure, employment, social infrastructure and social security will help ward off the global headwinds of recession. India will emerge stronger from this. ■